



Red-letter day: At just 23, Gayatri and Treesa became only the second Indian women's doubles pair to win a World Championships medal, ending a 15-year wait since Jwala Gutta and Ashwini Ponnappa's bronze.

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16th seeds Lauren Lam and Allison Lee 21-15, 21-12 in the second round, then swept past seventh-seeded Japanese pair Rin Iwanaga and Kie Nakanishi 21-16, 21-12 in the pre-quarterfinals. The quarterfinal against China's world No. 4 Jia Yifan and Zhang Shuxian was the turning point.

The Indians lost the first game 16-21 and were staring at a pair with considerably greater experience at this level. But instead of allowing the occasion to swallow them, they changed the match. They attacked, took more initiative and began to impose themselves on the rallies. They won the next two games 21-15, 21-13, their first win over the Chinese pair in four meetings.

Even in the semifinals, on paper at least, the Indians were huge underdogs against world No. 1 and defending champions Liu Shengshu and Tan Ning.

But in the biggest match of their lives, for a while at least, the two 23-year-olds looked as though they

might actually win it.

They raced to an early 7-2 lead, only for the Chinese to reel off six straight points and take control, leading 11-7 at the interval. Treesa and Gayatri refused to fold. A 31-shot rally helped level the scores at 12-12, and the two pairs traded points until India edged ahead at 18-18. Then Treesa found a cross-court winner to put India in front, two Chinese errors handed them two game points, and they took the first when Liu and Tan sent a shot long. The Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium erupted. The crowd sensed it. That's when they chanted.

India had the world No. 1 pair on the ropes. Liu and Tan found a way out. The second game was tight early, level at 10-10, before the Chinese pulled clear to lead 14-12 and eventually closed it out 21-13. The decider was more one-sided still, the Chinese pair winning 21-8 in an hour and 11 minutes overall. But the full-throated celebration from an otherwise stoic pair said plenty about how much the win meant to them.

For the Indians, the dream of a World Championships final was over.

That bronze can be read in two ways. It can be seen as a reward for a good week. Or it can be viewed as evidence that a pair has reached a level from which bigger things are now possible. Gayatri and Treesa's medal belongs firmly in the second

Honour board



Men's singles:

Gold: Alex Lanier (France)

Silver: Kodai Naraoka (Japan)

Bronze: Chou Tien-chen (Chinese Taipei), Victor Lai (Canada)

Women's singles:

Gold: An Se-young (South Korea)

Silver: Akane Yamaguchi (Japan)

Bronze: Wang Zhi Yi (China), Pornapawee Chochuwong (Thailand)

Men's doubles:

Gold: Liang Wei Keng and Wang Chang (China)

Silver: Aaron Chia and Soh Wooi Yik (Malaysia)

Bronze: Kim Wong-ho and Seo Seung-jae (South Korea), Lee Jhe-huei and Yang Po-hsuan (Chinese Taipei)

Women's doubles:

Gold: Baek Ha-na and Lee So-hee (South Korea)

Silver: Liu Shengshu and Tan Ning (China)

Bronze: Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand (India), Li Yijing and Luo Xumin (China)

Mixed doubles:

Gold: Thom Gicquel and Delphine Delrue (France)

Silver: Feng Yanzhe and Huang Dongping (China)

Bronze: Amri Syahnawi and Nita Violina Marwah (Indonesia), Jiang Zhenbang and Wei Yaxin (China)

category.

They have spent the last few years learning how to play together, learning how to deal with setbacks and, crucially, learning how to believe that their aggressive style can work against the world's best.

That patience was visible in Delhi.

So was the partnership.

Treesa is the more obvious attacking weapon. From the rear court, she can produce the kind of power that unsettles even elite opponents. Gayatri's contribution is subtler but just as important. She holds the middle, reads the game and provides the stability that allows Treesa to attack without constantly